Information Policy: Technology in the News – The Dangers of Online Age Verification

The worldwide growth and exposure to internet connectivity among all age groups has raised concerns about protecting minors online. This has led to increased interest in age verification technologies. Recent legislation like the Kids Internet and Digital Safety Act (H.R. 7757) aims to address online child safety concerns (Kids Internet and Digital Safety Act, [KIDS Act], 2026). At the same time, events like Discord's age verification controversy demonstrate the complexity of addressing this issue in practice (Malik, 2026). The core problem emerges that enforcing online age verification by collecting sensitive personal information poses risks that may outweigh otherwise well-intended benefits.

In terms of legislative policy approaches to confront online safety for minors, the Kids Internet and Digital Safety Act (H.R. 7757) was introduced to the U.S. House of Representatives on March 3rd, 2026, by Representative Brett Guthrie of Kentucky. The federal bill emphasizes the accountability of online platforms, requiring companies to implement safeguards for younger users (KIDS Act, 2026). These safeguards would plausibly rely on computerized age verification technology to enforce underage user protections at a large scale. However, despite the bill's intentions, implementing such policy raises questions about the unintended consequences associated with collecting, storing, and analyzing private data, especially the sensitive data of minors.

To illustrate this point, a recent TechCrunch article by Malik (2026) discusses Discord's decision in February, 2026 to delay its global implementation of age verification measures after public backlash following a major data breach. Just four months prior to requiring age verification for all users to access certain content, Discord admitted that "around 70,000 users" who had already participated in age verification measures had their sensitive data compromised.

This data potentially included information like their “government ID photos” (Malik, 2026). The article notes that “Discord had stated that users could only verify their age by either completing a facial age estimation or submitting an ID to Discord’s vendor partners ... [and will now include] the option to verify using a credit card” (Malik, 2026). This incident raises serious concerns about what can happen to private data, and how it can result in situations that are potentially far worse than the online safety issues these policies aim to prevent in the first place.

Consequently, the fundamental issue with online age verification technology is based in its inherent reliance on sensitive personal data. According to the Association for Computing Machinery (ACM), existing age-verification technologies like facial recognition and ID verification systems have inherent risks such as compromise and misuse (ACM U.S. Technology Policy Committee [USTPC], 2020). In a public policy statement, the committee declared that “[facial recognition] technology is not sufficiently mature and reliable to be safely and fairly utilized without appropriate safeguards against adversely impacting individuals” (USTPC, 2020). They go on to state that “[w]hile FR technology can be benign or beneficial in its application, its use has often compromised fundamental human and legal rights ... to privacy” (USTPC, 2020). Thus, in the way this technology exists today, the need to collect sensitive data to function could stand to do more potential harm than good to both minors and adults online.

Further, the implications of age-verification technologies extend beyond end-users to all of society, as well as to the information professionals who develop and implement these systems. A careful balance must be kept between regulatory compliance and ethical data management to ensure that user privacy is not compromised. Widespread adoption of strict age verification measures could result in mass surveillance practices and erase anonymity online even when managed without compromising incidents. When data breaches do happen, stakeholders like

individual people including children, individual and whole industries, as well as international financial markets can plausibly suffer serious damages. Because it is unlikely that compromising events can be totally prevented even with the best security protocols, at minimum, data collection should be extremely limited for the purposes of age verification. It also seems more practical and more ethical to rely on alternative online safety measures in most cases, such as improved content moderation and customizable parental controls. Responsibility for online safety should not fall solely on businesses and governments, but also on individuals and parents.

As demonstrated, the fundamental problem with enforcing online age verification through the collection of sensitive personal information creates risks that may outweigh any preventative safety benefits. The push for internet age verification may be rooted in efforts to make growing digital spaces safer for younger users, but threats like compromised identity through facial scans, government-issued ID's, or credit card information remain ever present. Both legislative efforts and industry implementations on behalf of online platforms bring to attention the complexity of addressing this issue. In the future, governments and companies should aim to limit data collection practices and consider less invasive alternatives to moderate online content while protecting user privacy.

References

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